

# CHURCH BOARD

## Role Definition, Terms of Reference (TORs) & Operating Manual

### Seventh-day Adventist Church

---

## 1. Purpose of This Document

This document helps the Church Board understand, organize, and faithfully execute its responsibilities according to the Church Manual.

It translates the Church Manual's expectations into practical workflows, routines, templates, and checklists so that the board can function as the chief committee of the church without confusing its authority with that of the church business meeting.

This document answers five practical questions:

1. What is the Church Board responsible for?
  2. What must the Board do regularly?
  3. What matters must come to the Board before going to the church?
  4. What reports, plans, recommendations, and decisions must the Board handle?
  5. How should the Board work with the pastor, officers, departments, committees, conference, and members?
- 

## 2. Manual Alignment Principle

This operating manual is governed by three rules:

1. No responsibility should be assigned to the Church Board unless it is grounded in the Church Manual.
2. All Board duties must map to the Manual's logic on disciple-making, membership, meetings, reports, finance, departments, committees, and church governance.
3. Where this document proposes templates, registers, calendars, or checklists, these are operating tools designed to help the Board faithfully execute Manual-based responsibilities. They are not new sources of authority.

In this document:

- **Manual requirement** means the duty is directly stated or clearly required by the Church Manual.
- **Operating tool** means a practical template, checklist, or rhythm that helps execute a Manual requirement.

- **Local adaptation** means the church may adjust the format without changing the Manual's requirements.
- 

## 3. The Office of the Church Board

### 3.1 Why the Church Board Matters

Every church must have a functioning board whose members have been elected during a church business meeting.

The Board serves as the chief committee of the church. Its first concern is not ordinary administration, but the church's mission of making disciples through evangelism, outreach to the community, and spiritual nurture and training of the church.

### 3.2 Core Identity of the Board

The Church Board is:

- The chief committee of the local church
- The coordinating body for the church's disciple-making plan
- The body responsible for overseeing church business between business meetings
- The body that receives reports from officers and departments
- The body that recommends, coordinates, reviews, and prepares matters for proper church action
- The body that ensures departments and ministries work together rather than separately or competitively

### 3.3 Operating Posture of the Board

The Board's work must be marked by:

- Mission focus
  - Faithfulness to biblical teaching
  - Care for church attendees
  - Coordination rather than competition
  - Proper respect for church authority
  - Regular review of progress
  - Orderly documentation through the Clerk
  - Cooperation with the pastor and conference
-

## 4. Guiding Principles

### 4.1 Disciple-Making Is the Board's First Work

The Church Manual identifies making disciples as the primary function of the church and, therefore, the primary function of the Board.

The Board should keep its first interests and highest energies on involving every member in proclaiming the good news and making disciples.

### 4.2 The Business Meeting Has Authority Over the Board

The church business meeting has authority over the Board and may delegate responsibilities to the Board in addition to those already assigned by the Church Manual.

The Board therefore operates within delegated and Manual-defined authority. It does not replace the church business meeting.

### 4.3 The Board Recommends; the Church Acts Where Required

The Board may recommend actions to the church, but it does not take final action where the Church Manual assigns authority to the church.

This is especially important in:

- Transfers of membership
- Removal from membership
- Discipline
- Major business requiring business meeting action
- Approval of budget and financial statements through the proper process

### 4.4 No Board Business Should Displace Evangelism

The Church Manual states that the Board should permit no other business to interfere with planning for evangelism.

If other business becomes too time-consuming, the Board should appoint committees to care for specific areas of church business and bring recommendations back to the Board.

### 4.5 The Board Works Through Reports, Plans, Recommendations, and Follow-Up

The Board receives reports, reviews plans, coordinates activities, recommends action, and tracks progress. It should not become merely a discussion forum.

## 4.6 The Board Must Work in Cooperation With the Pastor and Conference

The pastor regularly serving the church acts as chairperson of the Board. In some circumstances, an elder may act as chairperson with the approval of the pastor, or if the church is without a pastor, the conference president.

The church should secure counsel from conference officers on major matters.

---

## 5. Formal Responsibilities of the Church Board

The Board's responsibilities fall into ten major areas:

1. Disciple-making planning
2. Spiritual nurture and training
3. Membership review and reclaiming
4. Evangelism and outreach
5. Coordination of departmental programs
6. Mobilization of members for personal outreach
7. Follow-up of interests
8. Receiving departmental and officer reports
9. Financial oversight and regular treasurer reports
10. Promotion of Adventist education

Each area is described below.

---

## 6. Disciple-Making and Spiritual Nurture

### 6.1 Develop and Oversee a Disciple-Making Plan

**Manual basis:** The Board is responsible to develop and oversee an active, ongoing disciple-making plan that includes both spiritual nurture and evangelistic outreach. This plan is the most important item for the Board's attention.

The Board should ensure that the church has a clear plan for:

- Spiritual nurture of members
- Evangelistic outreach
- Member training
- Member involvement in mission
- Follow-up of interests
- Retention and reclaiming of inactive or separated members

## 6.2 Educate and Nurture Members

The Board is responsible to educate and nurture all members into a personal and dynamic relationship with Jesus Christ.

This includes encouraging a life that involves:

- Prayer
- Bible study
- Sabbath School attendance
- Witnessing
- Intentional spiritual growth
- Use of talents and spiritual gifts in the church and community

## 6.3 Keep Disciple-Making on the Board Agenda

Because disciple-making is the Board's primary work, the Board should not allow meeting agendas to be consumed by routine business alone.

A disciplined Board agenda should include:

- Spiritual nurture
  - Evangelism
  - Membership reclaiming
  - Departmental outreach coordination
  - Reports on progress and follow-up
- 

# 7. Membership Oversight and Reclaiming

## 7.1 Study the Membership List

**Manual basis:** The Board is responsible to study the membership list and initiate plans for reconnecting with members who have separated from the church.

The Board should work with the Clerk, pastor, elders, and relevant ministries to ensure that the membership list is not treated merely as a record, but as a pastoral and redemptive responsibility.

## 7.2 Retain and Reclaim Members

The Board should help the church create a strategy to retain and reclaim former and inactive members through:

- Regular redemptive membership review
- Reclaiming ministries

- Pastoral and elder follow-up
- Member visitation and correspondence
- Referral to ministries that can support reconnecting members

### 7.3 Membership Transfers

The Board may recommend favorably or otherwise to the church regarding transfers of membership.

The Board does not vote letters of transfer or receive members by letter. Final action on transfers belongs to the church.

### 7.4 Discipline and Removal From Membership

The Board may review cases and recommend to a business meeting the removal or discipline of members where sufficient cause exists.

The Board does not have the right to take final disciplinary action, except to record removal at death or at the member's request where the Manual provides for that process.

---

## 8. Evangelism and Outreach

### 8.1 Evangelize the Outreach Territory

The Board is responsible to evangelize the outreach territory of the church.

Once each quarter, an entire Board meeting should be devoted to plans for evangelism.

### 8.2 Study Conference Recommendations

The Board should study conference recommendations for evangelistic programs and methods and how they can be implemented locally.

### 8.3 Initiate Public Evangelistic Planning

The pastor and Board initiate and develop plans for public evangelistic meetings.

The Board should ensure that public evangelistic plans include:

- Preparation
- Member involvement
- Departmental coordination
- Follow-up
- Interest tracking
- Reporting on results

## 8.4 Coordinate Departmental Outreach

Each department develops its plans for outreach within its own sphere, but before completing and announcing any program, each department should submit its plans to the Board for approval.

The Board coordinates timing, volunteer needs, and overall mission alignment so that departmental programs strengthen rather than compete with one another.

---

## 9. Departments, Reports, and Follow-Up

### 9.1 Coordinate Church Departments

The Board coordinates the work of the church's departments and ministries so that the church functions as one body.

Coordination should prevent:

- Conflicting dates
- Competition for volunteers
- Duplication of effort
- Isolated programming
- Weak follow-up after outreach events

### 9.2 Receive Departmental Reports

Each department should report at least quarterly to the Board and to members at business meetings or Sabbath meetings regarding spiritual nurture and evangelism.

The Board should maintain a report calendar so that each department reports regularly.

### 9.3 Receive Treasurer and Officer Reports

The Board should receive regular reports from the treasurer on the church's finances.

Other officers should report periodically.

### 9.4 Interest Follow-Up

The Board should encourage the interest coordinator to ensure that every interest is personally and promptly followed up by assigned laypersons.

The Board should not merely receive names of interests; it should ensure that responsibility for follow-up is assigned and tracked.

---

## 10. Financial Oversight and Committees

### 10.1 Financial Oversight

The Board oversees church finances and receives regular reports from the treasurer.

Financial oversight includes reviewing the church's financial position, ensuring that financial matters are handled through proper channels, and recommending budget-related matters through the proper process.

### 10.2 Finance Committee

Each church should have a mission-driven, broadly based consultative financial planning and budgeting process.

In some churches this may take the form of a finance committee. In smaller churches, the Board may handle this process directly.

Where a finance committee exists, its responsibilities include:

- Reviewing budget requests
- Reviewing the annual operating budget
- Reviewing the financial position of the church as reflected in financial statements
- Recommending the budget and financial statement review to the Board
- Supporting onward recommendation to the business meeting for church action

### 10.3 Committees of the Board

When other business becomes too time-consuming, the Board should appoint committees to care for specific areas of church business, such as finance or church building projects.

Such committees make recommendations to the Board. They do not replace Board responsibility or church authority.

---

## 11. Officers, Meetings, and Records

### 11.1 Chairperson

The chairperson of the Board is the conference-appointed pastor.

If the pastor prefers not to act in this capacity or is unable to be present, the pastor may arrange for an elder to preside. If the church is without a pastor, this is done in counsel with the conference president.



## 11.2 Secretary

The Clerk serves as secretary of the Board and is responsible for recording, presenting, and preserving the minutes of meetings.

## 11.3 Meetings

Because the work of the Board is vital to the life, health, and growth of the church, it is recommended that the Board meet at least once each month, more frequently if needed.

It is well to fix the monthly meeting time for the same week and the same day each month.

## 11.4 Quorum and Participation

Each church should determine at a business meeting the number of Board members required to constitute a quorum at future meetings.

Where allowed by local law, Board members may participate by electronic conference or similar communication, provided all participants can communicate with each other at the same time and the church has authorized such participation according to the Manual's process.

Votes by proxy or letter are not permitted.

---

# 12. Board Membership

The Board is elected by the members at the time of the regular election of officers.

In addition to conference-appointed pastors, the church should elect a representative Board that includes the officers listed in the Church Manual, such as elders, head deacon, head deaconess, treasurer, clerk, interest coordinator, ministry leaders, and other officers appropriate to the local church structure.

The guiding principle is representative coordination of the church's mission, not merely assembling every active leader into a meeting.

---

# 13. Governance Relationship to the Business Meeting

## 13.1 Business Meeting Authority

The business meeting has authority over the Board.

Major items should be decided at a regular or specially called business meeting.

## 13.2 Board Recommendations to the Church

The Board prepares, reviews, and recommends matters that require church action, including:

- Membership transfers
- Membership removals where applicable
- Annual budget and financial statement review through proper process
- Major plans requiring church approval
- Reports and plans for the next year

## 13.3 Annual Reporting to the Church

At least once a year, reports covering church activities should be included on the business meeting agenda.

Based on those reports, a proposed plan of action for the next year, including an annual budget, should be presented for approval.

Where possible, reports and plans should be presented in writing.

---

# 14. Operating Calendar

## Monthly Board Rhythm

Every month, the Board should normally:

- Meet at the fixed monthly meeting time
- Review the prior minutes and action tracker
- Review membership matters requiring Board attention
- Receive treasurer report
- Receive scheduled officer or department reports
- Review progress on disciple-making and outreach plans
- Approve departmental plans before they are announced
- Assign responsibility for follow-up actions

## Quarterly Board Rhythm

Every quarter, the Board should normally:

- Devote one entire meeting to evangelism planning
- Review departmental reports on spiritual nurture and evangelism
- Review interest follow-up status
- Review membership reclaiming progress

- Review financial position through treasurer or finance committee report
- Confirm that departments are working in harmony and not competing for dates or volunteers

## Annual Board Rhythm

Every year, the Board should normally:

- Prepare reports for the business meeting
  - Review annual church activity reports
  - Review and recommend a proposed plan of action for the next year
  - Review and recommend the annual budget through the proper process
  - Review committee performance and continuing needs
  - Support election transition and handover where needed
- 

## 15. Detailed Standard Operating Procedures

### SOP 1: Preparing for a Board Meeting

**Trigger:** Monthly or specially called Board meeting.

**Authority Check:** Meeting is called by proper authority and chaired according to the Manual.

**Steps:** 1. Confirm meeting date, time, place, and chairperson. 2. Prepare prior minutes for review. 3. Prepare action tracker from previous meeting. 4. Gather treasurer, officer, department, and committee reports due. 5. Prepare membership items requiring Board review or recommendation. 6. Identify any agenda items requiring church or conference action. 7. Ensure evangelism and disciple-making remain on the agenda.

**Output:** Board agenda pack.

### SOP 2: Conducting and Recording Board Decisions

**Trigger:** Board meeting held.

**Authority Check:** Quorum is present according to the church's adopted quorum.

**Steps:** 1. Confirm attendance and quorum. 2. Record decisions, recommendations, and assignments clearly. 3. Distinguish between Board action and items recommended to the church. 4. Record membership matters with exact wording. 5. Record deadlines, responsible persons, and reporting expectations. 6. Ensure non-Board business does not displace evangelism planning.

**Output:** Accurate Board minutes and action register.

## SOP 3: Developing and Reviewing the Disciple-Making Plan

**Trigger:** Annual planning cycle or Board review of mission priorities.

**Authority Check:** Plan remains within Church Manual and local church authority.

**Steps:** 1. Review the church's current spiritual nurture and evangelistic outreach activities. 2. Identify gaps in member nurture, training, witnessing, and follow-up. 3. Gather input from elders, Personal Ministries, Sabbath School, youth, and other departments. 4. Draft or update a disciple-making plan. 5. Assign responsibilities and timelines. 6. Review progress monthly and quarterly. 7. Present plan to the church where business meeting approval is required.

**Output:** Active disciple-making plan.

## SOP 4: Reviewing Membership Matters

**Trigger:** Transfer request, discipline matter, missing member concern, or membership review item.

**Authority Check:** Board may review and recommend; church takes final action where required.

**Steps:** 1. Receive item through pastor, elder, clerk, or authorized process. 2. Confirm whether the Board may act or only recommend. 3. Review facts carefully and pastorally. 4. Recommend action to the church where required. 5. Assign follow-up if restoration, reconciliation, or reclaiming is needed. 6. Ensure Clerk records action accurately.

**Output:** Board recommendation or authorized Board action.

## SOP 5: Coordinating Departmental Programs

**Trigger:** Department proposes a program or outreach plan.

**Authority Check:** Department plans must be submitted to the Board before completion and announcement.

**Steps:** 1. Receive proposed departmental plan. 2. Review alignment with church mission and calendar. 3. Check for conflicts in timing, volunteers, and resources. 4. Approve, adjust, or return for revision. 5. Record decision. 6. Require post-program report on progress and results.

**Output:** Coordinated and approved departmental plan.

## SOP 6: Quarterly Evangelism Planning Meeting

**Trigger:** Quarterly Board cycle.

**Authority Check:** Evangelism planning is a stated Board responsibility.

**Steps:** 1. Reserve an entire Board meeting for evangelism planning. 2. Review conference recommendations for evangelistic programs and methods. 3. Review current outreach territory and mission needs. 4. Review interest coordinator report. 5. Coordinate departmental contribution to evangelism. 6. Assign follow-up responsibilities. 7. Set reporting date for progress review.

**Output:** Quarterly evangelism action plan.

## SOP 7: Receiving Reports

**Trigger:** Monthly, quarterly, or scheduled reporting cycle.

**Authority Check:** Treasurer reports regularly; departments report at least quarterly on spiritual nurture and evangelism.

**Steps:** 1. Maintain reporting calendar. 2. Request reports before meeting. 3. Receive reports during meeting. 4. Record key decisions and follow-up items. 5. Refer issues requiring action to the relevant officer, department, committee, or business meeting. 6. Track unresolved items.

**Output:** Received reports and follow-up register.

## SOP 8: Appointing Committees of the Board

**Trigger:** Board business becomes too time-consuming or requires detailed review.

**Authority Check:** Committee serves the Board and makes recommendations back to the Board.

**Steps:** 1. Identify specific area needing committee attention. 2. Define committee purpose and scope. 3. Appoint chairperson and members. 4. Set reporting timeline. 5. Record appointment and terms of reference. 6. Receive committee recommendation. 7. Decide whether Board action or business meeting action is required.

**Output:** Committee appointment and recommendation.

## SOP 9: Budget and Finance Review

**Trigger:** Annual budget cycle or regular finance review.

**Authority Check:** Finance committee or Board reviews; budget and financial statement review proceed to Board and business meeting for action.

**Steps:** 1. Receive treasurer or finance committee report. 2. Review financial position. 3. Review budget requests. 4. Ensure the budget supports mission and local church needs. 5. Recommend annual operating budget to the Board if reviewed by committee. 6. Recommend final budget and financial statement review onward to business meeting for church action.

**Output:** Budget recommendation and financial review record.

---

## 16. Reports and Records

### 16.1 Reports the Board Should Receive

- Treasurer report
- Department reports
- Committee reports
- Interest coordinator report
- Membership review / reclaiming report
- Evangelism progress report
- Education-related report where applicable
- Annual church activity reports for business meeting preparation

### 16.2 Board Action Register

| Date | Item | Decision /<br>Recommend<br>ation | Responsible<br>Person | Deadline | Status |
|------|------|----------------------------------|-----------------------|----------|--------|
|------|------|----------------------------------|-----------------------|----------|--------|

### 16.3 Department Report Template

- Department:
- Reporting period:
- Spiritual nurture activities:
- Evangelistic outreach activities:
- Member involvement:
- Interests generated:
- Follow-up completed:
- Support needed from Board:
- Plans for next quarter:

### 16.4 Treasurer Report Review Template

- Reporting period:
- Opening balance:
- Income received:
- Expenses paid:
- Restricted / designated funds:
- Budget variance:
- Issues requiring Board attention:

- Recommendation, if any:

## 16.5 Membership Review / Reclaiming Report Template

- Total membership reviewed:
  - Members requiring follow-up:
  - Members contacted:
  - Members reconnected:
  - Members needing pastoral/elder visit:
  - Transfers pending:
  - Matters requiring Board recommendation:
- 

## 17. Checklists

### 17.1 Monthly Board Meeting Checklist

- ☐ Agenda prepared
- ☐ Prior minutes ready
- ☐ Treasurer report received
- ☐ Department reports scheduled
- ☐ Membership matters prepared
- ☐ Evangelism / disciple-making item included
- ☐ Action tracker updated

### 17.2 After Board Meeting Checklist

- ☐ Minutes drafted
- ☐ Actions assigned
- ☐ Recommendations to church identified
- ☐ Committee assignments recorded
- ☐ Follow-up deadlines noted
- ☐ Reports filed

### 17.3 Quarterly Evangelism Checklist

- ☐ Entire meeting reserved for evangelism planning
- ☐ Conference recommendations reviewed
- ☐ Outreach territory reviewed
- ☐ Departmental roles coordinated
- ☐ Interest follow-up reviewed
- ☐ Action plan recorded

### 17.4 Departmental Program Approval Checklist

- ☐ Plan submitted before announcement

- ☐ Dates checked
- ☐ Volunteer needs checked
- ☐ Budget/resource needs checked
- ☐ Follow-up plan included
- ☐ Reporting date set

### 17.5 Annual Business Meeting Preparation Checklist

- ☐ Reports gathered
  - ☐ Proposed plan of action prepared
  - ☐ Budget prepared/recommended through proper process
  - ☐ Written reports prepared where possible
  - ☐ Items requiring business meeting action identified
- 

## 18. First 90 Days for a New Church Board

### Days 1–30

- Confirm Board membership and officers
- Confirm chairperson and secretary
- Review Church Manual section on Church Board and meetings
- Confirm meeting schedule
- Review previous minutes and pending action list
- Receive current treasurer report
- Identify urgent membership, finance, or property matters

### Days 31–60

- Establish Board action tracker
- Establish reporting calendar for departments and officers
- Review current disciple-making and evangelism plans
- Review membership reclaiming needs
- Confirm process for departmental program approvals

### Days 61–90

- Hold first focused evangelism planning discussion or meeting
  - Review departmental coordination gaps
  - Review interest follow-up process
  - Confirm quarterly reporting rhythm
  - Prepare any items requiring church business meeting action
-



## 19. What Good Board Performance Looks Like

A strong Church Board keeps disciple-making at the center of its agenda, coordinates the work of departments, receives reports regularly, protects proper church process, recommends matters to the church where required, and ensures that plans are followed through.

The Board does not merely meet; it governs mission, nurture, outreach, membership care, finance, and coordination in an orderly and spiritual manner.

---

## 20. Risks if the Board Function Is Weak

If the Board's work is weak, the church may experience:

- Meetings dominated by routine business rather than mission
  - Poor coordination between departments
  - Weak follow-up of interests
  - Inactive members left unreclaimed
  - Financial decisions without sufficient review
  - Confusion between Board authority and church authority
  - Delayed or improper membership recommendations
  - Poor preparation for business meetings
  - Ministry programs that compete rather than cooperate
- 

## 21. Suggested Appendices to Add Later

1. Sample Board agenda
  2. Sample Board minutes
  3. Annual disciple-making plan template
  4. Quarterly evangelism planning template
  5. Department reporting calendar
  6. Committee terms of reference template
  7. Annual business meeting preparation pack
  8. Finance committee TORs
  9. Membership review workflow
  10. Board orientation checklist
-

## 22. Closing Note

The Church Board is not merely an administrative meeting. It is the chief committee through which the local church organizes its life for disciple-making, spiritual nurture, evangelistic outreach, member care, financial oversight, and coordinated service.

Its authority must remain within the Church Manual, under the church business meeting where required, and in cooperation with the pastor and conference.

When the Board works well, the church's mission is not left to chance. It is planned, coordinated, reviewed, and carried forward with order and spiritual purpose.